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THE USE OF TRUMPET ON BOARD SHIPS OF THE DUTCH EAST INDIA COMPANY

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edited by Elisa Koehler

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THE USE OF TRUMPET ON BOARD SHIPS OF THE DUTCH EAST INDIA COMPANY

BY RALPH HENSSEN

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This article was reviewed and approved for publication by the ITG Editorial Committee.

By the end of the 16th century, Dutch trade with Spain and Portugal diminished as a result of several wars as well as the Spanish “pepper contracts” which gave competing international firms exclusive rights to lower prices. Consequently, a number of Dutch companies decided to start trading with the Dutch East Indies independently, with their own ships. Most of the time, the founders financed these new companies themselves with the help of outside investors. Fierce competition erupted between these new companies—especially the Amsterdam and the Zeeland companies—at the turn of the 17th century when surpluses of pepper and spices caused prices to drop on the European market. In an effort to stabilize the situation, government prosecutor Johan van Oldebarneveld initiated a merger of the competing companies into the Dutch East India Company, or *Verenigde Oost-Indische Compagnie* (voc), in 1602.

In an effort to guarantee the success of the new venture, the Dutch government granted voc a monopoly on trade with Asia for a period of 21 years. The cities that played a major role in engineering the new trading companies with the Dutch East Indies were also granted exclusive trading zones known as chambers in the trading territory. These chambers were established in Amsterdam, Middelburg (Zeeland), Rotterdam, Delft, Hoorn, and Enkhuizen (see Figure 1).

The Amsterdam chamber was by far the largest and was allocated half of all the trade of voc; the Zeeland chamber was the

second largest with one quarter of all activities. Each of the four remaining chambers shared $\frac{1}{6}$ of the remaining territory.¹

The Trumpeters of the VOC

From the very beginning, the ships of the Dutch East India Company, or *Verenigde Oost-Indische Compagnie* (voc), usually had one or more trumpeters stationed on board; however, virtually nothing is known about their duties. This publication will explore the role of the trumpeter² on board sea-going vessels in the 17th and 18th century through the prism of these voc ships. Although this inquiry primarily concerns the trumpeters employed by the Middelburg voc chamber, we may assume that other voc chambers acted according to the same rules and regulations. The muster-rolls of the return ships of the Middelburg voc chamber have been published in seventeen volumes which contain the names of all the sailors (including the trumpeters) that served for more than one hundred years on ships of the Zeeland voc³. This data has made it possible to study the percentage of ships that carried a trumpeter (whether or not in combination with a drummer) as well as the origin of the various trumpeters.

The Trumpeter in the 17th and 18th Centuries

Between about 1600 and 1800, trumpet players were commonly ranked into three different categories based on their level of education: musical, non-musical, and instrumental. Any person who wanted to learn the trade of trumpet playing served an apprenticeship for two years with a master. After this apprenticeship he generally became a so-called non-musical trumpet player who was deemed fit for signalling service or for playing the lower and middle parts in the trumpet ensemble, where the range comprised the second to the eighth harmonics of the overtone series.

After this two year training he started his apprenticeship, in which he specialized in one particular field.⁴ J.E. Altenburg distinguishes several fields for the non-musical trumpet players. Among other things, he could be trained to be a court trumpet player, city trumpeter, field trumpeter, or to be a ship's trumpeter.⁵ The musical trumpeter was better trained (was more gifted) than the non-musical, although his apprenticeship also took two years. Besides playing the signals he was capable of taking part in musical activities like playing the clarino parts in the trumpet ensemble and performing at banquets (the so-called *Tafelblazen*). The musical trumpet player at court was often referred to as the Parlour trumpet player or the Concert trumpet player.

The difference between the musical and the instrumental trumpet player was that the latter also had an elaborate general musical knowledge and moreover played one or more other instruments besides the trumpet. For this reason, the instrumental trumpet players often formed part of a musical college



Figure 1: VOC Chambers

at court. For example, in Salzburg, one could only be hired as a court trumpeter if he were able to play a string instrument and was therefore deemed to be a “musician.” Because little is known about the duties of the ship’s trumpet players, this publication will attempt to shed light on their work, particularly on board the VOC ships.

The Ship’s Trumpet Player

Since the middle ages, sea-going vessels have carried trumpet players.⁶ It is even suggested by Herbert Heyde that the name clarino, originates from the word *clarasius* translated literally as “a wind instrument belonging to a ship,” one of the medieval names for a trumpet.⁷ Until the end of the 14th century the coiled trumpet or conch shell would be referred to as a *clarion*⁸ in England. Although J.E. Altenburg mentions the ship’s trumpet player in his treatise, *Versuch einer Anleitung zur heroisch-musikalischen Trompeter-und Paukerkunst* (published in 1795), he gives no further explanation about the tasks and work of this kind of trumpeter. Altenburg only writes one sentence about the work of the ship’s trumpet player: “A ship’s trumpeter is one (be he trained or not) who seeks his fortune on the high seas.”⁹

The distinction between “trained” or “not trained” [*gelernt* and *nicht gelernt*] implies that the former, besides sounding the usual signals, is also capable of participating in concert music (i.e. able to produce the higher harmonics). The “untrained” [*nicht gelernter*] on the contrary, is only capable of sounding the necessary signals. The ship’s trumpet player may well be considered a kind of field trumpet player whose major duty was to sound signals to the crew and to other ships.¹⁰

The Dutch VOC-specialist Herman Ketting writes in his book, *Life, Work, and Rebellion on Board of the Ships of India-men*: “If someone had some musical talent, he could be hired as a drummer or a trumpeter for sounding the signals.”¹¹ Because the profession of a trumpeter was protected, it is doubtful that anyone with a modicum of musical talent could easily enter the ranks (apart from the fact that the musical qualities of the average ship’s trumpeter were probably not very high). Neither does the geographical origin of the trumpeters employed by VOC indicate this, as will be seen later; therefore, we can assume that this remark by Ketting only applies to drummers.

This ship’s trumpeter was an important member of the crew who took care of the communication between the ships of the fleet as well as between the command and the crew on board. The fact that the trumpet could serve as a means of communication becomes clear from the description of the duties of the ship’s trumpeter on board the Swedish flagship Kronan (which exploded during a battle in 1676). The trumpeter’s duties comprised sounding the call for morning and evening prayers, for the hoisting of the flag, and for various other signals. Besides that, the ship’s trumpet was sounded (or the ship’s drum was beat) during periods of dense fog and low visibility in order to assemble the fleet.¹² Although article X of the 1785 signal letter of VOC does not show that the trumpeter was supposed to give signals in case of fog, (the contact should be made through musket shots), it is quite obvious that they were given in actual practice.¹³ The trumpet also sounded when guests were welcomed on board by the captain. Another duty of the ship’s trumpeter was to sound death-knells when the body of a deceased person was lowered over the side of a ship.¹⁴

The ship’s trumpet was therefore a means of communication, comparable to the ship’s drum (or the ship’s bell), which could be used for similar purposes.

A well-known anecdote about the use of the trumpet as a means of communication describes how Abel Tasman reached New Zealand on December 13, 1642, and tried to make contact with the inhabitants (the Maori) through trumpet signals. The Maori interpreted the sound to be a declaration of war and attacked the sloop, killing three members of the crew.

Duties of the VOC Ship’s Trumpeter

The Instructions for Deck Officers at Sea of November 16, 1744, show that only ships of a certain size carried a ship’s trumpeter.

VI. All ships of 136, 145, 150 feet and more, will sail with a double number of officers, going to the East Indies, i.e., with a Boatswain, a Boatswain’s mate,..., provided that they all together with the General officers, Surgeons, Trumpeter or other employees [...] in total should not be more than the above mentioned number of 100, 90, or 80 heads going to the East Indies, and on the home trip 10 heads more for each Chartering [...], all together on a home trip amounting to 120, 110 and 100 heads [...].¹⁵

However, muster rolls show that not all ships of this size actually carried a trumpeter. It was also common practice for a trumpeter to be found on ships of only 130 feet in length. The abovementioned *Instruction* additionally stipulates that ships were to have a permanent staff from that time on. Consequently, the maximum number of permanent crew members for a voyage to the Dutch East Indies was set at one hundred men for ships of 150 feet in length, ninety for ships of 145 feet, and eighty for ships of 137 feet.¹⁶ For the homeward voyage it was allowed to have twenty extra sailors on board. Such numbers indicate that the use of the trumpet or the drum for giving the various signals can be assumed.

The specific duties of the ship’s trumpeter employed by VOC were numerous. For example, when a ship left port, trumpet signals sounded, salutes rang out, and the ship’s drum was beat.¹⁷ These duties are largely comparable to those previously described on board the Swedish flagship Kronan. A passage from a report by a ship’s surgeon, Nicolaus de Graaff, of a journey named *Image of the Dutch East Indies* concerns the duties of drummers and trumpeters on board VOC ships:

The drummers and trumpeters are obliged to sound watch in the morning and the evening and to beat the drum, as they also should do when the cabin crew is eating. They should also blow the trumpet whenever any vessel sails alongside or on land when people come on board from other ships. The drummer and the trumpeter eat together from the steward’s or cook’s bowl; also from the saloon table.¹⁸

This passage shows that the duties of the drummers and the trumpeters were indeed identical. A reference to this practice appears in the description of the duties of trumpeters and drummers in times of distress:

So when in times of distress the trumpet sounds or the drum is beat, everyone should show great diligence to come into defence in his quarter, and thus resist the enemy with good discipline, under the

explicit promise, that the wounded will be duly cured with good measure by the surgeons.¹⁹

The fact that a sick or deceased trumpeter was sometimes replaced by a drummer during a stop on the Cape provides further evidence that the duties of a drummer and a trumpeter were similar. Therefore it may well be presumed that the following article from the *Instruction for the Chief Officers at Sea* of November 16, 1744, also applies to the ship's trumpeter:

Every night at exactly 8 o'clock the commander will fire a shot five minutes after the tattoo has sounded.

After this, all drums will sound tattoo on the other ships and stop simultaneously after two minutes.²⁰

As is shown below, in many cases a VOC ship carried a trumpeter as well as a drummer. Because a drummer had a lower rank than a trumpeter (and accordingly received less salary) it is not surprising that there were more ships that carried only a drummer than ships with just a trumpeter. Furthermore, in those days it was relatively difficult to find a competent trumpeter, since the profession of trumpeter was protected (especially in Germany) and entrance was restricted. In many cases,

Period	Number of departures	Number of ships carrying only a trumpeter	Number of ships carrying two trumpeters	Number of ships carrying one or more trumpeters and drummers	Number of ships carrying only one or more drummer
1671 – 1679	43	11		1	
1680 – 1689	48	12			
1690 – 1699	45	22			
1700 – 1709	58	3		30	21
1710 – 1719	72	3		45	20
1720 – 1729	89	6		34	41
1730 – 1739	97	5		49	30
1740 – 1749	67	5		28	32
1750 – 1759	66	4		43	17
1760 – 1769	66	6	1	39	18
1770 – 1779	61	10		23	20
1780 – 1789	50	3		2	14
1790 – 1794	32	1		1	10
<i>Total</i>	<i>794</i>	<i>91</i>	<i>1</i>	<i>295</i>	<i>223</i>

Derived from: P.F. Poortvliet—The officers and the Zeeland seamen of the ships of the Zeeland VOC chamber (“Het kader en de Zeeuwse zeelui van de uitgaande schepen van de VOC kamer Zeeland”) (1996)

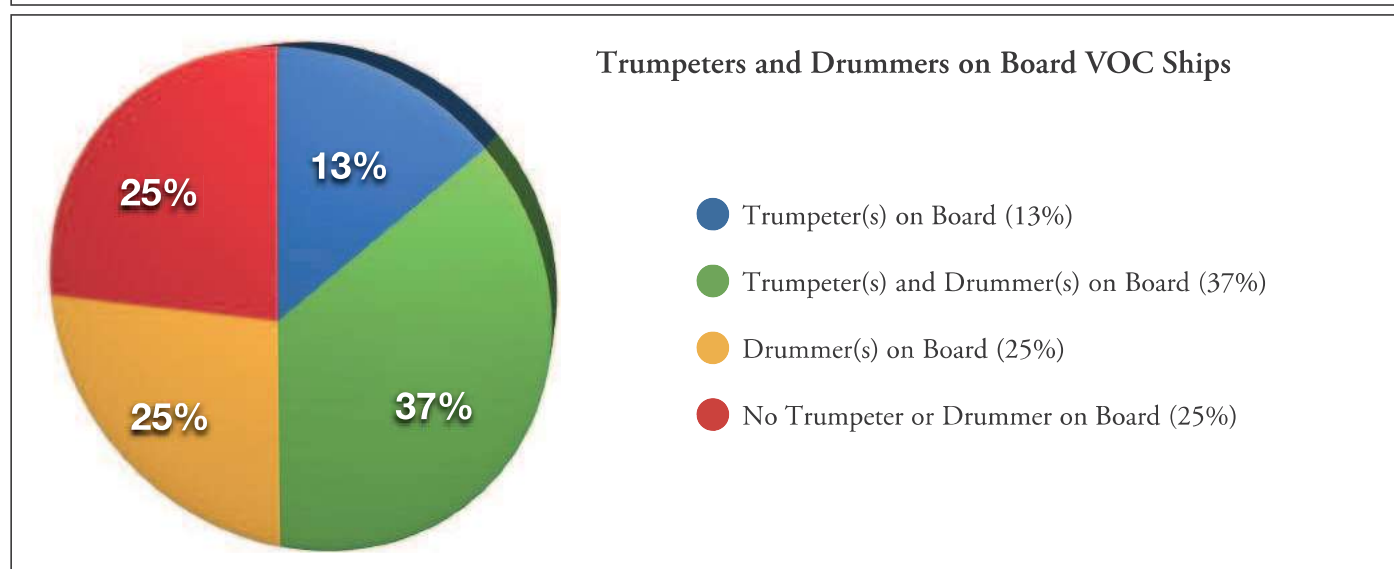


Figure 2: Number of VOC ships carrying trumpeters and/or drummers

however, neither a drummer nor a trumpeter was on board. The presence of a trumpeter on a ship (in addition to a drummer) was, as stated previously, often dependent on the size of the ship. Peter Kolb confirms this when he writes in 1727, “Besides a drummer, Dutch East India Ships (I am not discussing warships) normally have their own trumpeter.”²¹

The trumpet served also as a means of communication between ships of the fleet. Paintings that depict VOC ships often show that trumpeters are pointing in the direction of other ships when playing. Therefore it can be assumed that these ships communicated by means of trumpet signals. Studying the muster rolls of the ships of the Middelburg VOC chamber between 1671 and 1794, it is notable that two ships (in one case even three) often had the same departure and arrival dates for their voyages to Batavia. As becomes clear from the muster rolls, these ships usually had a trumpeter on board who most likely contributed to the communication between these ships during the voyage.²² It should also be noted that contact was made by a call of the trumpet or the drum when approaching an unknown vessel, and suspicion arose when the other ship failed to reply in kind with its own trumpeter or drummer.²³

A closer look at the survey of the muster rolls of the outward bound ships of the Middelburg VOC chamber leads to a number of conclusions about the presence of trumpeters and drummers on the VOC ships (see Figure 2).²⁴ Of the 794 ships that sailed during this period, 91 had only one trumpeter on board, one ship had two trumpeters on board, 295 ships had one or two trumpeters and one or more drummers on board, and 223 ships had one or more drummers on board. Prior to 1700, however, practically no drummers are to be found on board the ships. In that period only one of the 136 ships carried a drummer (even in combination with a trumpeter) and 45 carried a trumpeter. In some cases a trumpeter came on board at the Cape, in the middle of the voyage, either to replace a sick or deceased colleague or as an additional trumpeter who continued his (interrupted) voyage to the Dutch East Indies.

In summary, it may be said that about one trumpeter sailed on half of these outward-bound ships.²⁵

The Rank of the Ship's Trumpeter

On board VOC ships the crew was divided into categories called *dishes*, so that men of about the same rank ate from one bowl. Such groups were called dishpeople (or in Dutch: baksvolk).²⁶ Nicolaus de Graaff (the previously mentioned ship's surgeon) wrote about this practice, “The drummer and the trumpeter eat together from the steward's or cook's bowl; also from the saloon table”²⁷ and also observed that “The steward, the steward's mate, the cooper, the trumpeter, quartermasters and the deputy master eat together.”²⁸ The trumpeter belonged with the petty officers; this also appears on the (incomplete) *List of petty officers for the ship, 't Slot der Hoge, size 150 Feet* (after 1777) and from the *List of deck officers for the ship, Ouw-erkerk, size 150 Feet* (after 1769).²⁹ Like the other sailors in the higher ranks, the trumpeters generally enlisted for three years, which did not include the time needed for the round trip.³⁰

Little is known about the typical career of a ship's trumpeter. The 346 trumpeters mentioned in the muster rolls of the Middelburg VOC chamber include only a few examples of promotions to a higher post and of promotions from a lower post to that of a trumpeter. For example, the trumpeter Harmen Smith from Herregersdorp³¹ of the VOC-ship “Vrijburg” also

served as a quartermaster during the voyage to Batavia on the Cape from 1695 to 1696 (probably a temporary measure, as there was no salary increase). Daniël de Strooband from Hooghstrate was appointed trumpeter of the VOC ship *Aagtekerke* in 1721, but between 1722 and 1723, he sailed on the VOC-ship *Herstelde Leeuw* as midshipman. On board another VOC-ship, *Barbesteyn*, the following change took place on August 10, 1731, after the death of the steward on June 30, 1732: trumpeter Jan Hendrick Ragostky from Hoesum was promoted to steward and the able seaman Hendrik Lodewijk Zinger from Hessencassel was promoted to trumpeter. Moreover, during a stop on the Cape, the trumpeter of the perished VOC ship *Slot ter Hoge* came on board the *Barbesteyn*.

Other examples of promotions include Johannes Wolst from Bergen op Zoom who boarded the VOC ship *Huis Om* in 1764 on the Cape as a trumpeter after previously serving as a corporal on board the VOC ship *Duijnenburg*. François Gabriel Gramam from Lyon worked as a trumpeter between 1777 and 1778 on board the VOC ship *Willem de Vijfde* after serving as a soldier on “the state ship Allarm.”

Because only three of these men became trumpeters by promotion, it may be concluded that the training for a ship's trumpeter did not take place on board the ship. The fact that the abovementioned Hendrik Lodewijk Zinger, Johannes Wolst and François Gabriel Gramam were promoted to trumpeter, implies that the VOC did not always make heavy demands on the musical abilities of the trumpeters. As shown above, the trumpet was used for sounding signals and amateur trumpet players did not exist in those days, as the profession of trumpet player was highly protected.

One case is known of a student drummer on board a VOC ship. During the voyage of the *Westhoven* to Batavia between 1745 and 1746 the muster roll mentions a drummer as well as a junior drummer. This voyage probably served as apprenticeship for the student drummer.³²

The hierarchy of a typical ship's crew may be deduced from the partially incomplete *List of Deck officers for the Ship Ouw-erkerk, size 150 Feet*³³:

- Deputy Master (2 times)
- Third Master
- Boatswain
 - His mate
- Roper
 - His mate
- Steward
 - His mate
- Cook
 - His mate
- Master gunner
 - His mate (3 times)
- Chief cooper
 - His mate
- Chief sail maker
- Deputy sail maker
- Provost
- Quartermaster (4 times)
- Trumpeter
- Ship's corporal
- Ship's carpenter

The deputy master, third master, boatswain, roper and quartermaster were responsible for navigating and operating the

ship. The master gunner, the chief cooper, the chief and deputy sail makers, and the ship's carpenter took care of the maintenance of the ship and the guns. The steward and the cook took care of the crew's well being. The provost was in charge of order and hygiene on board.³⁴

Salary

In the Regulations [...] on promoting company servants of December 7, 1699, the pay of the ship's trumpeter is mentioned: "trumpeters that are engaged in the home country normally have a pay of 18 guilders" (a monthly salary).³⁵ Trumpeters also worked on the VOC yards. On the *Roll of the workers and dockers on the Yard of the Dutch East India Company in the year 1749*,³⁶ we can establish the presence of trumpeter Daniel Appeldoren on "t Groote Jagt".³⁷ He was paid 24 five cent pieces (per month). By way of comparison, the shipmaster received 32 five cent pieces (per month), the cook earned 26, and both the steward and the sailors earned 20.³⁸ We also find a trumpeter named Willem Ulrich on "het Groote Jagt" according to an undated (18th century) list of the workers on the yards.³⁹

When the wages of some deputy officers of VOC ships in the 17th century are compared⁴⁰ (see Figure 3), it becomes clear that a trumpeter's salary is not much less than that of the "higher deputy officers" such as the boatswain, the roper, the steward, the cook, the master gunner and the cooper.

Crew Member	Monthly Salary (Guilders)
Boatswain	18 – 26
His mate	14 – 15
Roper	16 – 22
His mate	14
Steward	20 – 26
His mate	14
Cook	15 – 24
His mate	14 – 15
Master gunner	18 – 26
His mate	14
Cooper	16 – 26
Chief sail maker	16
Deputy sail maker	8
Provost	15 – 16
Quartermaster	13 – 15
Trumpeter	16 – 22
Ship's corporal	14 – 16
Able seaman	12
Drummer	8 – 10
Sailor	9 – 10

Figure 3: Salary of crew members on board 17th-century VOC-ships

For some contemporary perspective, it should be noted that the monthly wages of craftsmen like bricklayers and carpenters in 17th-century Netherlands ranged between 17 and 27 guilders whereas unskilled labourers earned between 8 and 14 guilders per month.

National Origin of the Trumpeters

The majority of VOC trumpeters came from either the Netherlands (34.5%) or from Germany (36.2%), according to the muster rolls of the outward bound ships of the Middelburg VOC chamber between 1671 and 1794 mentioned above (see Figure 4). In the first half of this period (prior to 1734) the Dutch are predominant (both from the North and the South Netherlands), but after 1734 the number of trumpeters of German origin prevail. Only a few trumpeters are from Scandinavia, France, England, Switzerland, Italy, and Russia. Besides those, three trumpeters appear to have come from other countries.⁴¹

Although most trumpeters came mainly from the Northern Netherlands and Germany, this is not always the case for drummers. They often appear to come from the direct surroundings: the South Netherlands (especially from [Zeeland] Flanders and towns like Maastricht and Bergen op Zoom).

Number of Voyages

As mentioned previously, a trumpeter employed by the VOC signed for a three-year period, not counting the length of the voyage. When examining the names of the trumpeters on board the outbound VOC ships of the Middelburg chamber, it is conspicuous that the majority only made one return voyage. A large number of trumpeters probably stayed in the Dutch East Indies, where some of them undoubtedly practiced their profession in the employ of dignitaries and local nobility whereas others died during or shortly after the journey.

In this period (1671 – 1794), a trumpeter is mentioned 401 times on ships' registers. The 387 voyages these trumpeters made, however, were completed by no less than 346 different trumpeters. Some trumpeters sailed on more than one voyage. For example, two trumpeters made four return voyages: Daniël Appeldoorn between 1753 and 1765, and Frans (or Francois) Kramers (between 1772 and 1776), both from Middelburg. Seven trumpeters made three return voyages⁴² and 34 trumpeters went on two voyages. It follows that the majority of the trumpeters employed by the Middelburg VOC chamber probably only sailed on one return voyage to the Dutch East Indies (see Figure 5).

Although many trumpeters remained in the Dutch East Indies, some continued their employment with another VOC chamber.

Another reason for the low percentage of completed voyages is the length of the trip to Batavia (between seven and ten months on average); another is that the physically trying voyage reaped several casualties.⁴³ Over 25% of the trumpeters mentioned above are registered to have died during the voyage or within one year of arriving in the Dutch East Indies. For example, 43 trumpeters died on board during a voyage to the Dutch East Indies (one of them even died before the ship embarked). Twelve trumpeters died in a hospital on the Cape (where a stopover took place), and 49 trumpeters died in Batavia Hospital within a year of arriving in the Dutch East Indies, most likely after an illness (see Figure 6).

Country of Origin: [†]	Netherlands	Germany	Belgium	France	Denmark	Sweden	Great Britain	Switzerland	East Indies [‡]	Norway	Italy	Russia	Luxembourg	Croatia	Poland	Africa [‡]	Unknown	Total
Period																		
1671 – 1679	11		1															12
1680 – 1689	6	1	2														2	11
1690 – 1699	8	6	6														1	21
1700 – 1709	16	6	5			1				1					1		1	31
1710 – 1719	29	7	2	1	1				1		1						1	43
1720 – 1729	9	12	7	1	1		1										1	32
1730 – 1739	15	25	6		2												4	52
1740 – 1749	7	11	3	1		1	1	1	1			1		1		1	1	30
1750 – 1759	7	20	9					1					1				2	40
1760 – 1769	5	20	4	1		1		1	1								5	38
1770 – 1779	5	14	2	3		1											4	29
1780 – 1789	1	4																5
1790 – 1794																	2	2
Total	119	126	47	7	4	4	2	3	3	1	1	1	1	1	1	1	24	346
Percentage	34.5	36.2	13.6	2.0	1.1	1.1	0.6	0.9	0.9	0.3	0.3	0.3	0.3	0.3	0.3	0.3	7.0	100

[†] Country of origin according to the present day borders. D: Germany, NL: Netherlands, B: Belgium, F: France, Dk: Denmark, S: Sweden, GB: Great Britain, Ch: Switzerland, Ind: East Indies, Nor: Norway, I: Italy, Ru: Russia, L: Luxemburg, Afr: Africa

[‡] The trumpeters from the East Indies and Africa were in view of the fact that their names sound familiar probably of European origin.

Derived from: P.F. Poortvliet—The officers and the Zeeland seamen of the ships of the Zeeland voc chamber (“Het kader en de Zeeuwse zeelui van de uitgaande schepen van de voc kamer Zeeland”) (1996).

Note: Trumpeters who took part in more than one journey are counted only once.

Figure 4: Origin of the trumpeters

The death rate on ships to Asia rose during the 18th century. Between 1700 and 1750 seven percent died on the way to the Cape and over ten percent on the way from the Cape to the Dutch East Indies; between 1750 and 1780 these percent-

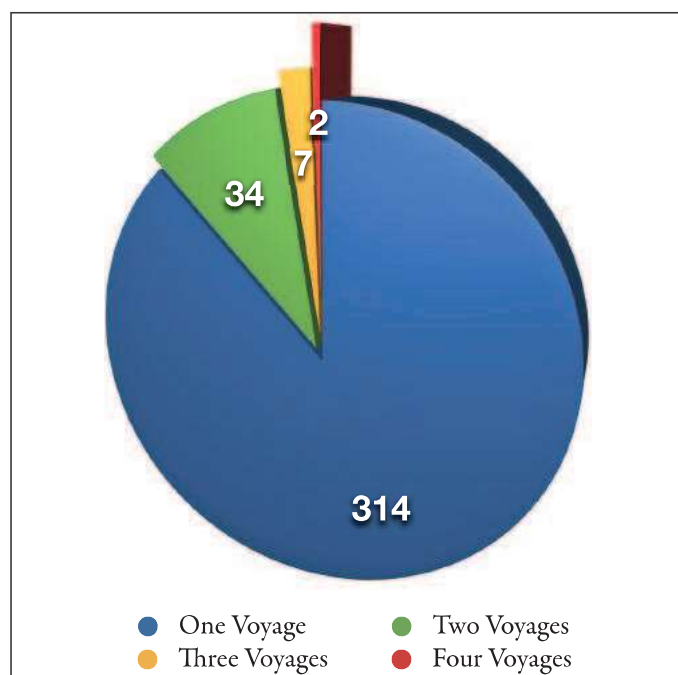


Figure 5: Number of return voyages for trumpeters

ages went up to eight and twelve percent, respectively.⁴⁴ A trumpeter was often shot during battle because of his unprotected station on the poop deck. On the other hand, a trumpeter had a better chance to survive than common sailors if the ship surrendered to capture because he had a skill to offer.⁴⁵

A number of trumpeters are also known to have died some years later in the Dutch East Indies. Adventurers may have used a trumpeter's post as a way to relocate in the Dutch East Indies, or they might have died as a result of the demanding crossing on another voc ship. It is also known that seven trumpeters deserted in the Dutch East Indies (or did not show up when the ship left); two deserted after arriving on the Cape. One trumpeter, Frederik Augustus Phaff from Frankfurt am Main, was noted as missing when a ship departed for the Netherlands in 1762. As has been previously mentioned, trumpeters who died in the Cape hospital or during the voyage to the Cape were sometimes replaced by a drummer instead of a trumpeter.⁴⁶ Also, the fact that ship's trumpeters apparently offered their services to different employers, probably explains why some were employed by the voc for only one return voyage. It is also possible that some considered a paid voyage to the Dutch East Indies to be an adventure.

The Instruments

Muster rolls and crew lists from several voc ships show that the taller vessels often had a trumpeter on board.⁴⁷ For example, the “saloon ware” of the ship “Stabroek” consisted of

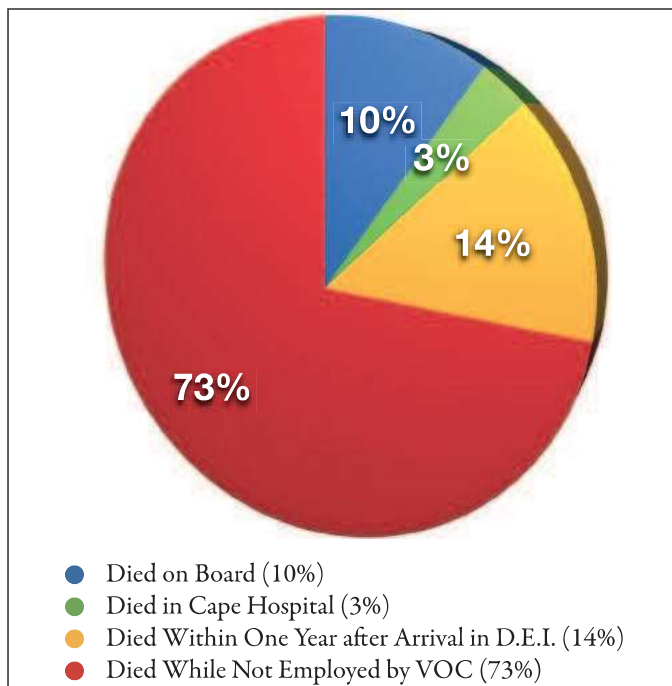


Figure 6: Deaths of VOC trumpeters

“1 case with trumpet” among other things for a voyage that set sail in July 1726.⁴⁸ In a similar vein, on the printed *List of the Ship’s ammunitions on behalf of the ship [...] sailing to the Dutch East Indies* we find a “case with a trumpet.”⁴⁹

When raising perished VOC ships (e.g., ‘t Vliegende Hart, Hollandia, Batavia, Witte Leeuw), a number of trumpets have been brought to the surface. All of these instruments were made in Germany.⁵⁰ This is not surprising because the VOC purchased their trumpets from the so-called Nuremberg shops. As the name implies, these shops sold products from Nuremberg, the center of metalworking in the 17th and 18th centuries.⁵¹ For example, in November 1747 the VOC bought 26 brass trumpets for the amount of 109 Dutch guilders at the Nuremberg shop of Isaac van Zaan en Zoon in the Warmoesstraat in Amsterdam; in December 1748 another 18 trumpets were acquired. Another Amsterdam Nuremberg shop of the time was that of Wed. George Lodewijk Matthes, also established in the Warmoesstraat.⁵²

In the printed Lists of the provisions⁵³ of several ships of the Middelburg VOC chamber the last item is a “Neurenborger Trumpet” (see Figure 7).⁵⁴

These lists show where the Middelburg chamber bought these Nuremberger Trumpets as well as mirrors (“Spiegels”):

- Alblasserdam (300 heads)
 - : 1 Neurenborger Trumpet—J. van den Broecke
- Voorland (300 heads)
 - : 1 Neurenborger Trumpet—J. van den Broecke
- De Zuidpool (200 heads)
 - : 1 Neurenborger Trumpet—J. van den Broecke
- De Swaan (300 heads)
 - : 1 Neurenborger Trumpet—Corn. de Koetsier
- Mentor (150 heads)
 - : 1 Neurenborger Trumpet—A. Koekman

From these data and from the large number of trumpets that were bought in 1747 and 1748 in Amsterdam, it may be concluded that the ship’s trumpet lasted exactly one return voyage.

Also because of the fact that a trumpet was a comparatively

vulnerable instrument in the 17th and the 18th century, it may be assumed that such an instrument did not last longer than one round trip voyage.

In addition to trumpets, “Nuremberg ware” also comprised mirrors, scissors, knives, and other metal items that were often used to purchase slaves.⁵⁵ This explains why trumpets were usually bought in combination with mirrors. Along with trumpets that were used as ship’s trumpets, the VOC also bought “(brass) Nuremberg trumpets” belonging to the military provisions at a price of “4¼, 4½ Dutch guilders a piece.”⁵⁶

The trumpet found in the wreckage of the ship ‘t Vliegende Hart (perished in 1735) may have been the ship’s trumpet because the vessel’s equipment list includes a “case with trumpet.”⁵⁷ However, a trumpeter’s name did not appear on the muster roll, so it is quite possible that the instrument was classified as a military item because there were 83 soldiers on board.⁵⁸ A third possibility is that the instrument was owned by a musician because two horns were found along with this trumpet. Given the large number of crew members (172) and the size of the ship (145 feet), it is surprising that no ship’s trumpeter or drummer was on board.⁵⁹

The ship’s trumpet of the VOC ship *Batavia* (wrecked in 1629) has also been recovered. This instrument was made by Conrad Droschel (1596 – 1644) from Nuremberg.⁶⁰ The

LYSTE van de Viſtualien, noodig voor Compagnies Schip <i>Melasserdam</i> volgens de <i>Tonier</i> Lijst voor 300 Koppen.	
46000	Hard Brood, met 600 <i>Wit brood</i> en 100 <i>Wit brood</i>
—	Wit dito.
—	Stokvis; Lenge.
—	Gefoute Vis.
—	Tonnen Pekelharing van 800 ps. yder Ton.
—	Ps. Rootkoft Meykaas van 7 a 8 yder.
—	Vaten Booter.
—	Zyroop tot Bier en Brood.
—	Of Stukken Pruymen.
—	Zakken Gort.
—	Dito Graauwe Erten.
—	Dito Blaauwe Erten.
—	Dito Witte Boonen.
—	Dito Garfte, 12 <i>Zakken Schapeboonen</i>
—	Dito Molter-zaat.
—	Roete
—	Half Wafle } Kaarsfen.
—	Heel Wafle }
—	Half Amen met Blomme.
—	Dito met Boekweyde Meel.
—	Volle Zeugen.
—	Jonge Loop Varkens, 12 <i>Schape</i>
—	Koppel Jonge Leg-Hoenders.
—	Quartjes Delfsche Boter.
—	Jonge } Kafan
—	Komynne }
—	Ps. Westphaalsche Hammen.
—	Ps. Rook-Vlees.
—	Ps. dito Ofte Tongen.
A 150 Zyroop	

150	Zyroop.
50	Lang Rozijn.
50	Corenten.
20	Annijs } Zaat.
20	Comijn }
6	Heele Gengber.
15	Spaansche Zeep.
10	Loot Safferaan. <i>in een Doosje</i>
2	Ps. Hammelakens.
2	Ps. Hand-doeken.
2	Ps. Servetten.
2	Ps. Groene Sitte-Kuffens.
2	Ps. Spiegels. <i>in een Klee</i>
2	De Gordijnen en Behangfels die noodig zullen zyn
1	Ps. Neurenborger Trompet.

Figure 7: List of Provisions

trumpet on board of the *Hollandia* was made by Sathler in Leipzig rather than a maker in Nuremberg.

Ship's Trumpeters as Musicians

As has previously been shown, the duty of a ship's trumpeter was not considered an artistic job. Indeed, playing the signals did not amount to much, musically, because the signals were limited to only a small number of harmonics.⁶¹ The primary concern was that the signals were loud enough to ensure order and effective communication for all on board. Still, this did not mean that those who sounded the signals did not have talent; there are indications that some ship's trumpeters were also capable of making music.⁶² Peter Kolb writes in his *Precise and Elaborate Description of The Cape of Good Hope*:

If the captain wants some amusement, for example when the weather is fine and the wind is good (for otherwise partying is out of the question, as you will understand) then he also makes use of the trumpeter and has him play a rondeau or something of the kind, and because there is seldom a ship with that many people without a few men that play an instrument, they are also put into action on these occasions.⁶³

It is possible that the two horns made by Eigentopf (Leipzig, 1732) found in the wreckage of the VOC ship, *'t Vliegende Hart*,⁶⁴ were used for similar musical occasions.⁶⁵ Furthermore, the fact that someone named Johan Christiaan Pistorius worked as musician (not as a trumpeter) with the Zeeland Admiralty before he mustered in as trumpeter on the VOC ship *Alblasserdam* in 1789, shows that some trumpeters must also have been musically educated.

More clues for the musical use of the trumpet on board are the dimensions of the mouthpiece of the ship's trumpet that was found in the wreckage of the *Hollandia* (sunk in 1743). The trumpet was made by Sathler from Leipzig, and one tail end of a branch and a part of its garland are still intact.⁶⁶ The matching mouthpiece (see Figure 8) has such a bore and size that are, mildly speaking, less suitable for playing (loud) signals.⁶⁷ On the other hand, the size is such that the mouthpiece is perfectly suited for musical purposes.⁶⁸



Figure 8: Copy of the Sathler mouthpiece (R. Henssen 1997)

A trumpet mouthpiece was also found in the wreckage of the ship *De Witte Leeuw* (1613).⁶⁹ As was usual at the beginning of the 17th century, this mouthpiece is relatively large, deep and composed of several parts.⁷⁰ The mouthpiece is gilded, and its shank carries the inscription "LZE." The mouthpiece is not exactly suited to playing music because its dimensions are so large; it might be played loudly and with a harsh sound in the

lower register.

Another ship's trumpet is Lissandro Milanese from Genua's instrument found in Dutch waters.⁷¹ This instrument, constructed in 1589, was complete enough to be fully reconstructed.⁷² Moreover, two mouthpieces were found with the instrument, one of which is of such dimensions that it can only be used to play signals (comparable to the mouthpiece from *De Witte Leeuw* described above). The other mouthpiece is made of lead, looks clumsy, and seems to have been adapted by hand, but the dimensions are such that it was probably used for musical playing.⁷³

Conclusion

The role of the ship's trumpeter was comparable to that of a field trumpeter. His duties consisted of giving signals to crewmembers and to other ships. Consequently, artistic musical performances were not expected from a typical ship's trumpeter. Of course, this does not mean that musically adept trumpeters never sailed the high seas. In fact there are indications that some ship's trumpeters made music during their journey. And the presence of two Eigentopf horns on board of the VOC ship *'t Vliegende Hart* might lead to the conclusion that these were probably used (maybe by the ship's trumpeter) for musical performances on board the ship.

Little is known about the training of the ship's trumpeter. However, considering the fact that a crew member was hardly ever promoted to trumpeter, it can be assumed that the ship's trumpeter served a two years' apprenticeship with a master before he came on board for the first time. Although no evidence has been found of this, it may even be assumed that someone could not call himself a ship's trumpeter until he had served during a long voyage. Here, an analogy can be drawn with the field trumpeter, who could not bear this title before he had experienced a battle.

Approximately half of all outward-bound VOC ships carried one or more trumpeters on board. In three quarters of these cases a trumpeter and/or drummer were present. The duties of the drummer were similar to those of the trumpeter. The drummer, however, was lower in rank. The majority of the

trumpeters originated from the Netherlands and from Germany, the majority of the drummers came from the surrounding area (Zeeland, Flanders and Limburg).

The trumpets used on board of the VOC ships were bought by the VOC as Neurenborger trumpets in so called Nuremberg shops. From the large number of instruments bought every year, it may be concluded that a ship's trumpet lasted only one round trip voyage.

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and drummers in the Netherlands during the 17th and 18th centuries.

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Endnotes

1. H. Ketting, *Life, work and rebellion on board of the ships of Indiamen* (1595 – 1650) (Amsterdam 2002), 15.
2. The occupation of trumpeter or trumpet player was practised only by men in this period. It should be remarked that the term, "trumpeter," is used when duties involve signalling (not in the musical field); the term, "trumpet player," on the other hand is mainly used when duties are situated in the musical field.
3. P.F. Poortvliet, *The officers and the Zeeland seamen of the ships of the Zeeland voc chamber* (Nieuwdorp 1996 – 1999).
4. D. Altenburg, *Untersuchungen zur Geschichte der Trompete im Zeitalter der Clarinblaskunst* (1500 – 1800) (Regensburg 1973), 68 – 80.
5. J.E. Altenburg, *Versuch einer Anleitung zur Heroisch-Musikalischen Trompeter und Pauker-kunst* (Halle 1795), 26 – 30.
6. H. Heyde, *Trompete und Trompetebblasen im europäischen Mittelalter* (Leipzig 1965), drawing 3.
7. *Clarasius* is derived from *classis*, meaning "ship" or "fleet."
8. H. Heyde, *Trompete und Trompetebblasen*, 26.
9. J.E. Altenburg, *Versuch einer Anleitung*, 30 [Ein Schiffstrompeter ist derjenige, der (er seij ein gelernter oder

- nicht) auf dem weiten Meere sein Glück versucht].
10. Both activities are shown in a painting by Andries van Eertveldt (F. Gaastra *The history of voc* (Zutphen 2002), 2 – 3).
 11. H. Ketting, *Life, work and rebellion* (Amsterdam 2002), 39.
 12. E. Kjellberg, 'Who played Music on Board the Royal Flagship Kronan? Identifications, Definitions and Historical Considerations', *Second Conference of the ICTM Study Group on Music Archaeology Vol. I* (1986), 109.
 13. *Seyn-brief Vereenigde Oost-Indische Compagnie...* (Middelburg, 1785).
 14. I. Woodfield, *English Musicians in the Age of Exploration* (Stuyvesant 1995), 61.
 15. "VI. *Alle schepen van 136, 145, 150 voeten, en daarboven, sullen varen met dubbele Officers, in het Land: dat is, met een Bootsman, een Schieman, [...], verstaande dat dese alle te samen met de opper-Officieren, Chirurgyens, Trompetter of andere Bedienden [...] in alles niet meer zullen moeten uytmaken dan het bovenbepaalde getal van 100, 90, of 80 koppen in 't Land, en op de thuyrs-reysen 10 koppen meer voor ieder Charter [...], dat dan alles op een thuyrsreyze 120, 110 en 100 koppen uytmaakt [...]*"
 16. This is considerably less than on the ship, 't *Vliegende Hart* (145 feet long), that sailed in 1735 with 172 crew members.
 17. H. Ketting, *Life, work and rebellion*, 69.
 18. N. de Graaff, *Image of the Dutch East Indies* (Oost-Indise Spiegel) (Hoorn, 1703), 55 in: J.C.M. Warnsinck ed., *Travels of Nicolaus de Graaff to all territories of the world, Works of the Linschoten-Vereeniging* 33 (Den Haag 1930). "*De Tamboers en Trompetters zijn verpligt 's morgens en 's avonds de Wagte te blasen, en op de trommel te slaan; gelijk sy ook gehouden zijn te doen wanneer het Kajuyts volk aan tafel is. Desgelijks zijn sy ook gehouden te blasen, so wanneer eenig vaartuyg van boord vaart, of aan land, of van andere Schepen aan boord komt. De Tamboer en Trompetters eten gemeenlijk aan de Botteliers of Koksbak; ook wel aan de Kajuyts natafel.*"
 19. Article XLI from: Article-letter of the chartered Dutch East India Company (Middelburg September 4, 1742); also to be found in the Article—letters 1634 – art. XL; 1658 – art XXXIX; 1672 – art XXXIX. "*Zo wanneer in tyd van nood de Trompet word gesteken, of den Trommel geslagen, zal een iegelyk, met alle dilligentie voortkomen op lijfstraffen, om zig terstond onder zyn quartier in defensie te stellen, en also met goede ordre den Vyand te resisteren, onder expresse belofte, dat de gequetste met goede middelen van Chirurgyens zullen gecureert worden na behooren.*"
 20. Instruction for the Chief officers at Sea of November 16, 1744, 20. "*Alle avonden precies ten agt uren, zal den Commandeur van de Rhede op wagte afschieten; na dat vyf minuten bevorens de Taptoe op zyn Schip geslagen heeft, en zodra de schoot gedaan word, zullen alle de Trommels op de andere Schepen de Taptoe slaan, twee minuten lang, en dan te gelyk ophouden, en de wagte opgeset worden, desgelijks zal de Commandeur van de Rhede des morgens als het begint te ligten reveille slaan, even voor de reveille van 't Casteel, of de Hoofd-wagte, waar na sig de andere Posten aan Land komen te rigten...*"
 21. V. Roeper and R. van Gelder, *Employed by the company. Life with voc in one hundred testimonies* [1602 – 1799] (Amsterdam 2002), 55.
 22. P.F. Poortvliet, *The officers and the Zeeland seamen of the ships of the Zeeland voc chamber* (Nieuwdorp 1996).
 23. I Woodfield, *English Musicians in the Age of Exploration*, 57.
 24. P.F. Poortvliet, *The officers and the Zeeland seamen*.
 25. On the voc ship *Batavia* (that sailed on October 29, 1628 from Texel and was wrecked on June 4, 1629) the crew of 303 souls included three trumpeters: chief trumpeter Claes Janszoon from Dortrecht, main trumpeter Jacob Groenewaldt and deputy trumpeter Cornelis Pieterszoon "the fat one." Gretler, Parthesius & van der Zee (1991).
 26. J.R. Bruijn and J. Lucassen ed., *On the ships of the Dutch East India Company*. Five articles by J. de Hullu (Groningen 1980), 116.
 27. N. de Graaff, *Image of the Dutch East Indies* (Oost-Indise Spiegel) (Hoorn, 1703), 55 in: J.C.M. Warnsinck ed., *Travels of Nicolaus de Graaff to all territories of the world, Works of the Linschoten-Vereeniging* 33 (Den Haag 1930). "*De Tamboer en Trompetters eten gemeenlijk aan de Botteliers of Koksbak; ook wel aan de Kajuyts natafel.*"
 28. N. de Graaf, *Image of the Dutch East Indies*, 58. "*De Bottelier, Botteliersmaat, Kuyper, Trompetter, Quartiermeesters en Ondermeester eten by malkander.*"
 29. B. Mathias Pous Tak, ZA 255 – 227.
 30. R. van Gelder, *The Dutch East Indian adventure* (Nijmegen 1997), 205.
 31. Because the present name of each town is not always known, the names have been rendered as they appear in the muster rolls.
 32. P.F. Poortvliet, *The officers and the Zeeland seamen*, part 8.
 33. B. Mathias Pous Tak, ZA 255 – 227.
 34. H. Ketting, *Life, work and rebellion*, insert.
 35. J. de Hullu, ZA 474 – 111.
 36. Mathias Pous Tak, ZA 255 – 233.
 37. Later he sails as a trumpeter on the voc ships "Hercules" (1753/54), "Thoornvliet" (1757), "Vosmaar" (1761), "Nieuw Rhoon" (1765/66) to Batavia.
 38. Mathias Pous Tak, ZA 255 – 233.
 39. Mathias Pous Tak, ZA 255 – 227.
 40. S. Deconinck, "I'm going for a good catch." *Southern Dutch people employed by the Dutch East India Company* (1602 – 1660) (Gent 1992).
 41. In view of their names (Jacobus Leander from Batavia, Barend van Bentem from Bantam and Jan van den Ruigenhoek from Africa), these men probably all originated from Europe and not from Indonesia and Africa, respectively.
 42. Claas Brand, Jan Boeijs (or Boije or Boijinck), Ary van der Ketel (or Adriaan Ketel), Carel Martijn Straatsenbag, Michiel Oijmans (or Haeijmans or Hoeijmans), Lodewijk Toelje (or Foelje or Foelie) and Hans Michiel Sinkel.
 43. For that reason, trumpeters employed by voc generally stayed with voc for a relatively short time. This contrasts with the trumpeters employed by the Admiralty, where employments of decades are no exception.
 44. J.R. Bruijn, e.a., *Dutch Asiatic Shipping I* (Den Haag 1979), 162 – 167.

45. I. Woodfield, English Musicians in the Age of Exploration, 71.
46. Trumpeter Joh. Willem van Bredestein from St. Maartensdijk died on January 19, 1768, in the Cape hospital and was replaced by a drummer.
47. J. Gawronski, The crew of the Hollandia and Amsterdam (Amsterdam 1996), 201; R. Paesie, The voc ship Ravesteyn (Amsterdam 1999), 183.
48. R. Paesie, The voc ship Ravesteyn, 183; ARA VOC 10036.
49. J. de Hullu ZA 474 – 112.
50. Constructing a trumpet was obviously done by hand and also in view of the large numbers it speaks for itself that the instruments were not made in the Netherlands. The Netherlands had only very few builders of brass wind instruments (like in England, these instruments were constructed by silversmiths most of the time). See paragraph x.
51. In particular brass and gold working (K. Pechstein, “Die Merkzeichentafel der Nürnberger Trompeten- und Posaunenmacher von 1640”), Mitteilungen des Vereins für Geschichte der Stadt Nürnberg, Band 59 (Nürnberg 1972), 198.
52. J. Gawronski, The Crew, 198.
53. List of provisions of around 1790; Mathias Pous Tak, ZA 255 – 233.
54. Only one of the lists is dated, the one of the rented ship De Eensgezindheid. This is dated March 25, 1794.
55. J. Chr. Hoffmann (1672) in: V. Roeper and R. van Gelder, Employed by the Company, 99.
56. J. Gawronski, The Crew, 201.
57. This concerns a (brass) trumpet made by Georg Friedrich Steinmetz, the biggest part of which is now kept in the Rijksmuseum in Amsterdam (inv. Nr. NG 1986-46-7) and a fragment (a piece of tube) in the Maritime museum in Vlissingen (inv. Nr. 0971).
58. P.F. Poortvliet, The officers and the Zeeland seamen, deel 9.
59. W. Weber, A sunken voc ship. ‘t Vliegent Hart. (Middelburg 1987) and ARA 11.854.
60. A part of the bell rim was recovered, see J.N. Green, “The loss of the V.O.C. Retourship ‘Batavia’, Western Australia, 1629,” British Archaeological Reports (Oxford 1989).
61. Primarily between the second and eighth partials of the overtone series.
62. Apparently a “gelernter Trompeter” is meant here, as defined by J.E. Altenburg.
63. Peter Kolb (1704) in: V. Roeper and R. van Gelder, Employed by the Company, 55. “*Als de kapitein zin heeft om zich wat te vermaken, bijvoorbeeld als het mooi weer is en de wind goed (want anders wordt, zoals u begrijpt, aan geen feestvieren gedacht), dan bedient hij zich ook van de trompetter, en laat hem een rondeau of iets dergelijks blazen, en omdat er zelden een schip is met zoveel volk, waar er niet een paar bij zijn die op een instrument kunnen spelen, worden die bij deze gelegenheden ook ingezet.*”
64. In the Maritime Museum in Vlissingen the mouth tube, the rim and the original mouthpiece of the horn are on display. The mouthpiece (inv. Nr. 1989 0647) is in exceptional good state. Eigentopf was a contemporary and a fellow citizen of J.S. Bach and that he and Bach developed instruments like the Oboe da Caccia together.
65. Of course, the horns may also have belonged to the luggage of the ship.
66. Rijksmuseum Amsterdam, inv. Nr. 80, H2019.
67. Rijksmuseum Amsterdam, inv. Nr. 80, H1161. The dimensions of the mouthpiece are: bore 4.2 mm, inner rim diameter 18.0 mm and outer rim diameter of 30.0 mm.
68. A copy of this mouthpiece made by the author in 1997 has demonstrated this.
69. Rijksmuseum Amsterdam nr. NG 1977 266W.
70. With a 23 mm inner diameter, a 32 mm outer diameter.
71. This trumpet was found on the location Scheurrak S01. This is east of the island of Texel.
72. The trumpet was reconstructed by Geert Jan van der Heide from Putten in 1994.
73. G.J. van der Heide, ‘Reconstruction of a special Italian trumpet from the site Scheurrak S01,’ Fish and Fishing (Groningen 1994) and G.J. van der Heide, ‘The reconstruction of a 16th-century Italian trumpet,’ Historic Brass Society Journal volume 8 (1996), 42 – 52.

